

Play policy

Extra time is a play provision, where playing is paramount to children's enjoyment of their lives and their health.

Childhood is not a singular, universal phenomenon experienced in the same way by all children

Children and young people, whatever their age, *need and want to play*.

This is documented in **Article 31 of the UN Convention on the Rights of the Child**, ratified by the UK government in 1991. The government has a duty under this convention to protect and promote play opportunities for all children and young people. **Children have a right to play** indoors and out, in whatever way they can. Through playing, children are creating their own culture and exploring their creativity.

Children need and want to challenge themselves when they play. Play provisions like ours encourage children to use play spaces within the provision that are stimulating and exciting and allows children to encounter and learn about risk. This helps them to build confidence.

Play allows children to:-

- Experience and encounter boundaries, learning to assess and manage risk in their lives; both physical and social.
- Understand the people and places in their lives, finding out about their environment and develop their sense of community.
- Find out about themselves, their abilities, as well as their own interests and what they can contribute in life.
- Play can be therapeutic for children; it can help to deal with difficult or painful circumstances such as emotional stress or medical treatments.
- Play can be a way of building and maintaining important relationships with friends, carers and family members.
- Allows the children to get dirty, enjoy different textures and feelings.

The role of the play worker (our staff)

The role of the play worker is to create a physical and social/emotional environment where children can play freely, rather than organising and directing activities aimed to offer an end product. Their role as a play worker is as important as that of any skilled professional working with children and should be respected and rewarded accordingly.

Children's play is enriched by the skills of the play workers, and the play workers are trained to put children's play needs at the centre of their work in their settings, enhancing the range of play experiences for all children. They are the best people to run a play provision for school-aged children like Extra Time.

Play workers will aspire to keep the setting, fun and Challenging for all children and will organise a variety of resources every day (we would ask parents to appreciate that we will keep your children as safe as we can, however throughout play children will get hurt from time to time and will get dirty as well, so please make sure they are not wearing their best clothes).

Play workers choose how and when to intervene when a child /ren are playing, which enables children and young people to extend their play. All play worker interventions must balance risk with the well-being of children and that all of the staff within Extra Time will adopt this approach and understand the level of intervention to achieve unadulterated play.

Enriching play environments, can offer these outcomes:

- **A varied and interesting environment.** Examples: things at different levels, spaces of different sizes, places to hide, trees and bushes as well as things that have been made, places to inspire mystery and imagination.
- **Challenge in relation to the physical environment.** Examples: activities which test the limits of capabilities, rough and tumble, sports and games, chase.
- **Playing with the natural elements - earth, water, fire, air.** Examples: campfires, digging, playing snowballs, flying kites.
- **Movement - e.g. running, jumping, rolling, climbing, balancing.** Examples: beams and ropes, soft mats, bike riding, juggling equipment, ladders, space.
- **Manipulating natural and fabricated materials.** Examples: materials for art, cooking, making and mending of all kinds; building dens; making concoctions; using tools; access to bits and pieces of all kinds.
- **Stimulation of the five senses.** Examples: music making, places where shouting is fine, quiet places, different colours and shapes, dark and bright places, cooking on a campfire, rotting leaves, a range of food and drink, objects that are soft, prickly, flexible, large and small.
- **Experiencing change in the natural and built environment.** Examples: experiencing the seasons through access to the outdoor environment; opportunities to take part in building, demolishing, or transforming the environment.
- **Social interactions.** Examples: being able to choose whether and when to play alone or with others, to negotiate, co-operate, compete and resolve conflicts. Being able to interact with individuals and groups of different ages, abilities, interests, gender, ethnicity and culture.
- **Playing with identity.** Examples: dressing up, role play, performing, taking on different kinds of responsibility.

Experiencing a range of emotions. Examples: opportunities to be powerful/powerless, scared/confident, like/disliked, in/out of control, brave/cowardly.

Recognising the benefits of play -

Play is great for children's well-being. When planning and providing play Opportunities, the goal is not to eliminate risk, but to weigh up the risks and benefits. No child will learn about risk if they are wrapped in cotton wool.

Managing risks whilst we play

The HSE (health and safety executive) fully supports the play provision for all children in a variety of environments.

The HSE understands and accepts that this means children will often be exposed to play Environments which, whilst well-managed, carry a degree of risk and sometimes potential danger.

The HSE fully recognises that play brings the world to life for children. It provides for an exploration and understanding of their abilities; exposes them to the realities of the world in which they will live, which is a world not free from risk but rather one where risk is ever present. The opportunity for play develops a child's risk awareness and prepares them for their future lives.

What parents and other professionals should expect from play providers -

Whilst providing play opportunities Extra Time staff focus on controlling the real risks, while securing or increasing the benefits – *'not on the paperwork'*. Staff use their own judgement and expertise as well as where appropriate, the judgement of others, to ensure that the assessments and controls proposed are proportionate to the risks involved. They will always communicate what these controls are, why they are necessary and so ensure every one focuses on the important risks.

Children and risk

All children both, need and want to take risks in order to explore limits, venture into new experiences and develop their capacities, from a very young age and from their earliest play experiences. Children would never learn to walk, climb stairs or ride a bicycle unless they were strongly motivated to respond to challenges involving a risk of injury.

Play provision and risks

Risk-taking is an essential feature of Extra Time, we aim to offer children the chance to encounter acceptable risks as part of a stimulating, challenging and controlled environment. *In the words of the play sector publication Best Play, play provision should aim to 'manage the balance between the need to offer risk and the need to keep children safe from harm'*

In Extra Time, the staff feel that the exposure to some risk is actually a benefit: it satisfies a basic human need and gives children the chance to learn about the real consequences of risk-taking.

Our policy for Play, was written in conjunction with the following:

Childrens play - <http://www.playengland.org.uk/media/71062/charter-for-childrens-play.pdf>

UN right of a child - <http://www.unicef.org/crc/>

Free play - <http://www.freeplaynetwork.org.uk/schools/appendix1.htm>

Managing risks -

<http://www.playengland.org.uk/media/120462/managing-risk-play-safety-forum.pdf>

Sign:

Position in club: Owner

Date reviewed: May 2025

next review date: May 2026

I the undersigned, am signing to say that I have reviewed this policy with the team, and will adhere to the policy at all times.

A.Grosse:

Date:

N.Walton:

Date:

H.Bailey:

Date:

T. Quinn:

Date:

M.Wright:

Date: